



GMC Guidance & Compliance Checklist

A Practical Setup Framework for New & Reinstated Stores

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About the Author

This framework is written by **Terry Ecom**, a Google Merchant Center specialist and the founder of GMC HELP.

Terry has worked hands-on with:

- New GMC account setups
- Reinstated and aged Merchant Center accounts
- Multi-store operations across multiple countries
- Long-term compliance and suspension prevention

This document reflects real-world enforcement patterns, not theory, and is based on practical experience supporting store owners inside the GMC HELP ecosystem.

Important Notice (Read First)

This document is a compliance and readiness framework, not an approval shortcut.

Google Merchant Center approvals are influenced by automated systems, human reviewers, and ongoing policy updates. While this checklist is designed to reduce risk and common rejection triggers, **approval is never guaranteed.**

This resource focuses on:

- Store setup
- Compliance alignment
- Risk reduction before and after submission

It does not replace advanced reinstatement strategies, escalations, or policy appeals.

Who This Framework Is For

This checklist is designed for:

- New Google Merchant Center accounts
- Recently reinstated GMCs
- Store owners preparing to submit or resubmit products
- Sellers running one or multiple stores who want to reduce linkage risk

This framework is **not** for:

- Guaranteed approvals
- Shortcut-based setups
- Policy manipulation or bypassing systems

How to Use This Checklist Correctly

Do not skim this document.

You should:

- Review every section carefully
- Verify your store against each checklist item
- Fix issues before submitting or resubmitting products
- Recheck compliance during the first 30 days after approval

Skipping steps often leads to:

- Instant disapprovals
- Silent suspensions
- Repeated policy flags

Many store owners combine structured manual checks with automated compliance scans to identify issues that are easy to miss.

Understanding Google's Risk Windows

Google Merchant Center accounts are most sensitive during the following periods:

■ First 48 Hours

- Automated systems scan your domain, products, policies, and business signals
- Many accounts fail here due to incomplete setup

■ First 7 Days

- Deeper automated checks and potential human review
- Policy mismatches are often caught at this stage

■ First 30 Days

- Ongoing monitoring
- Sudden or unnecessary changes can trigger reviews or suspensions

■ Risk Warning

Approval does not mean safety. Most suspensions happen after approval, not before.

Store Isolation Framework

(Critical for Multiple Stores)

If you operate more than one store, isolation is essential.

Recommended Structure (Per Store)

Each store should have:

- One Google Merchant Center account
- One Google Ads account
- One dedicated Gmail address
- One unique payment method
- One virtual or physical address
- One local phone number
- One clean IP or proxy
- One isolated browser profile (recommended)

■ Risk Warning

Do not reuse details across stores. Even small overlaps can create account linkage.

Multi-store linkage is one of the most common causes of repeated GMC suspensions.

Branding, Trust & Transparency

Google evaluates legitimacy, not aesthetics.

Compliance Checklist

- Use ™ or © symbols only if you legally own the rights
- Avoid fake urgency (false scarcity, misleading countdowns)
- Make contact details clickable (email and phone)
- Display contact information clearly in footer, contact page, and policy pages
- Use a professional business email address

Your store must look and function like a real business, not a temporary storefront.

Product Pages & Images

Product presentation is one of the most common rejection areas.

Image Rules

- No text overlays on product images
- No collage-style images
- No duplicate images across products
- No misleading visuals

Product Content

- Product title must match the product URL
- Titles and descriptions must be original
- Avoid exaggerated or unverifiable claims
- No fake or manipulated reviews

Many misrepresentation flags originate from title, image, or description mismatches.

Website Technical Alignment

Small technical mismatches cause big problems.

Technical Checklist

- Page speed score above 65
- Remove old or duplicate GMC verification codes
- Avoid duplicated themes across multiple stores
- Shopify settings must match footer, policy content, and business details
- Payment icons must match checkout options
- No broken links
- Archive out-of-stock products

■ Risk Warning

Inconsistencies across pages are a common review trigger.

Automated scans can detect mismatches that are easy to miss during manual review.

Shopify & Policy Consistency

Google compares:

- Store footer
- Policy pages
- Checkout information
- Merchant Center business details

All must align.

Even small differences (address formatting, payment methods, refund terms) can result in:

- Disapproval
- Account review
- Suspension

Final Pre-Submission Checklist

Before submitting or resubmitting products, confirm:

- All contact details are visible and clickable
- Policies are complete and consistent
- Product titles and URLs match
- Images meet Google standards
- No misleading claims or urgency
- Technical setup is clean
- No reused data across stores

X Avoid

If any item fails → do not submit yet.

Some sellers choose to run an additional automated compliance scan before submission to identify silent risk signals.

Ongoing Monitoring (After Approval)

Approval is not the end.

During the first 30 days:

- Avoid sudden changes
- Monitor product disapprovals closely
- Keep business details stable
- Recheck this checklist if issues arise

Ongoing monitoring tools can help surface issues before they escalate into suspensions.

Additional Support & Resources

This checklist represents a baseline compliance framework created and used by Terry Ecom within the GMC HELP ecosystem.

For sellers who want:

- Ongoing guidance
- Deeper store-level support
- Regular compliance oversight

i Additional Support

GMC HELP PRO (Paid Monthly Subscription)

→ <https://www.gmchelp.com/pro>

GMC Scout — Compliance scanning software used to identify common Merchant Center risk signals

→ <https://www.gmcscout.com>

Private 1-to-1 Calls with Terry Ecom

→ <https://calendly.com/terryecom>

These resources are optional and are not required to use this checklist effectively.

Final Notes from Terry Ecom

This document is designed to:

- Reduce unnecessary risk
- Improve submission readiness
- Help you build stores that survive review cycles

It does not guarantee approval.

For advanced approval strategies, reinstatements, or escalations, separate resources apply.

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